

High Blood Pressure and Older Adults

Source: National Institute on Aging (NIA), National Institutes of Health. Content reviewed October 1, 2022. U.S. Government work, public domain.

High blood pressure, or hypertension, is a major health problem that is common in older adults. Your body's network of blood vessels, known as the vascular system, changes with age. Arteries get stiffer, causing blood pressure to go up — this can be true even for people who have heart-healthy habits and feel just fine. High blood pressure, sometimes called “the silent killer,” often doesn't cause signs of illness that you can see or feel. Though it affects nearly half of all adults, many may not even be aware they have it.

If high blood pressure isn't controlled with lifestyle changes and medication, it can lead to serious health problems, including cardiovascular disease (such as heart disease and stroke), vascular dementia, eye problems, and kidney disease. The good news is that blood pressure can be controlled in most people.

What Is Blood Pressure?

Blood pressure is the force of blood pushing against the walls of arteries as the heart pumps blood. A reading is given as two numbers: systolic blood pressure (the pressure caused by your heart contracting and pushing out blood) over diastolic blood pressure (the pressure when your heart relaxes and fills with blood). Blood pressure levels are classified based on those two numbers:

- Low blood pressure (hypotension): systolic lower than 90, or diastolic lower than 60.
- Normal blood pressure: systolic less than 120 and diastolic less than 80.
- Elevated blood pressure: systolic between 120–129 with diastolic less than 80.
- High blood pressure: systolic of 130 or higher, or diastolic of 80 or higher.

For older adults, often the first number (systolic) is 130 or higher, but the second number (diastolic) is less than 80. This problem is called isolated systolic hypertension and is due to age-related stiffening of the major arteries. It is the most common form of high blood pressure in older adults and can lead to shortness of breath during light physical activity, lightheadedness upon standing too fast, and falls.

Do I Have High Blood Pressure?

Anyone can have high blood pressure. Some medical conditions, such as metabolic syndrome, kidney disease, and thyroid problems, can cause it. Some people have a greater chance of having it because of things they can't change:

- Age. The chance of having high blood pressure increases as you get older, especially isolated systolic hypertension.
- Sex. Before age 55, men have a greater chance of having high blood pressure. Women are more likely to have it after menopause.
- Family history. High blood pressure runs in some families.
- Race. African Americans are at increased risk for high blood pressure.

High blood pressure often has no signs or symptoms, but routine checks will help detect increasing levels. If a reading is high at two or more check-ups, a doctor may also ask you to measure your blood pressure at home.

How Can I Control My Blood Pressure?

You can often lower your blood pressure by changing your day-to-day habits and by taking medication if needed. Lifestyle changes that can help prevent and lower high blood pressure:

- Aim for a healthy weight. Being overweight adds to your risk of high blood pressure.
- Exercise. Moderate activity, such as brisk walking or swimming, can lower high blood pressure. Work up to at least 150 minutes (2.5 hours) per week.
- Eat a heart-healthy diet — such as the Dietary Approaches to Stop Hypertension (DASH) eating plan — which can lower your blood pressure.
- Cut down on salt. As you get older, the body and blood pressure become more sensitive to sodium. DASH is a low-salt diet.
- Drink less alcohol. Men should have no more than two drinks a day and women no more than one.
- Don't smoke. Smoking increases your risk for high blood pressure, heart disease, and stroke.
- Get a good night's sleep. Snoring or pauses in breathing during sleep may be a sign of sleep apnea; treating it can help lower blood pressure.
- Manage stress. Coping with problems and reducing stress can help lower high blood pressure.

In addition to lifestyle changes, your doctor will likely prescribe medication to lower your blood pressure to a safe level if needed. You may try several kinds or combinations of medications before finding a plan that works best for you. Medication can control blood pressure, but it can't cure it.

Research Shows the Benefits of Controlling High Blood Pressure

Preventing and controlling high blood pressure is important for heart health and may benefit brain health too. An NIH-funded study called the Systolic Blood Pressure Intervention Trial (SPRINT) found that lowering systolic blood pressure to less than 120 in adults age 50 and older significantly reduced the risk of cardiovascular disease and death. Related research found that lowering systolic blood pressure to less than 120 reduced the risk of mild cognitive impairment, and an analysis of several large, long-term studies found that treating high blood pressure was associated with a reduced risk of developing Alzheimer's disease.

Tips for Taking Blood Pressure Medication

- If your blood pressure goes down on medication, that means the medication and lifestyle changes are working — you still have high blood pressure, but it is being treated.
- Healthy lifestyle changes may help lower the dosage you need.
- Get up slowly from a seated or lying position and stand for a bit before walking, to prevent lightheadedness and falls.

- Tell your doctor about all the drugs, vitamins, and supplements you take.
- Take blood pressure medication at the same time each day as part of your daily routine.
- Refill your medication before you run out, and bring it with you when traveling.
- Before having surgery, ask your doctor if you should take your blood pressure medication that day.

For More Information About High Blood Pressure

- National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute (NHLBI) — 301-592-8573 — www.nhlbi.nih.gov
- MedlinePlus, National Library of Medicine — www.medlineplus.gov
- Million Hearts Initiative, CDC & CMS — millionhearts.hhs.gov
- American Heart Association — 800-242-8721 — www.heart.org

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